

The formation is a menu



HB-01 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

The familiar squares are useful reference points, not compulsory destinations. Black sometimes needs Nf6, ...h5, ...c5 or castling before a second fianchetto.

HOW TO DECIDE

Before each setup move, inspect White's next central advance and forcing threats. Choose the move that meets the position's needs, even if the final board no longer resembles a complete Hippo.

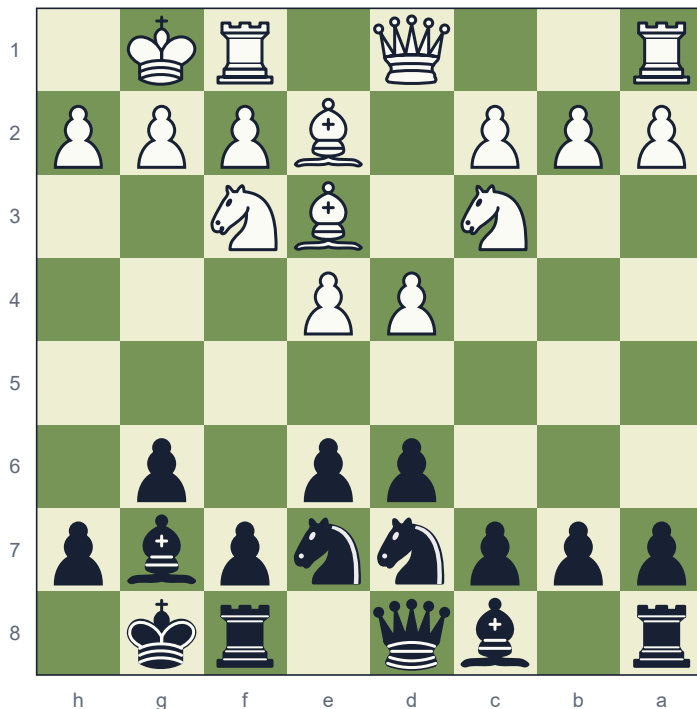
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White can seize space with c4 and f4 or attack with h4. A rigid ten-move script can turn a flexible system into a passive target.

BOARD DRILL

Take three branches and name the first move that departs from the full formation. Explain the concrete reason.

Which central break?



HB-19 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

...c5 challenges d4 from the side; ...d5 challenges e4 directly; ...e5 can close or contest the center; ...f5 is a more committal kingside lever. They are not interchangeable.

HOW TO DECIDE

For each candidate, calculate capture, advance and tension. Ask which bishop opens, which square weakens and whether the king is safe. Prepare the break with pieces when necessary.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White may answer ...c5 with d5 or ...d5 with e5, keeping a space advantage. Your break needs a plan for closure as well as exchanges.

BOARD DRILL

At a quiet endpoint, compare ...c5 and ...d5 in words and short legal variations.

Life with less space



HB-02 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

A compact position leaves fewer squares for pieces. Useful exchanges and timely breaks can relieve pressure; random waiting usually increases it.

HOW TO DECIDE

Identify the least active piece and a realistic route. Do not move it to a square another piece needs unless the exchange or maneuver has a clear benefit.

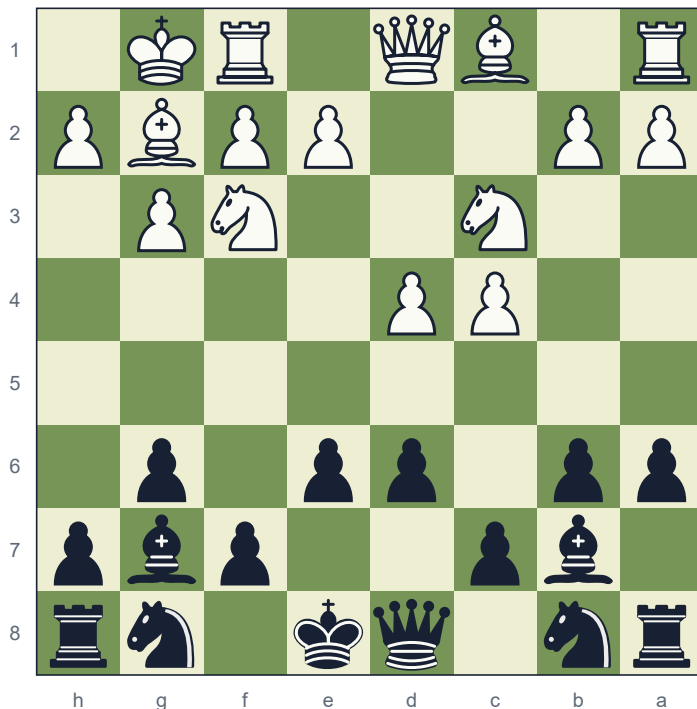
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White can improve every piece before opening the center. The absence of an immediate tactic does not mean Black has unlimited time.

BOARD DRILL

Play ten moves from a restrained endpoint and record whether each move improves a piece, prepares a break or answers a threat.

The two bishops need different openings



HB-04 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

Bb7 points toward e4 and the king side; Bg7 points toward d4 and the queen side. Own pawns may block both diagonals until the center changes.

HOW TO DECIDE

Trace each diagonal to its first blocker. Choose a pawn break that releases the bishop with meaningful targets. Avoid exchanging the active bishop while preserving only the blocked one.

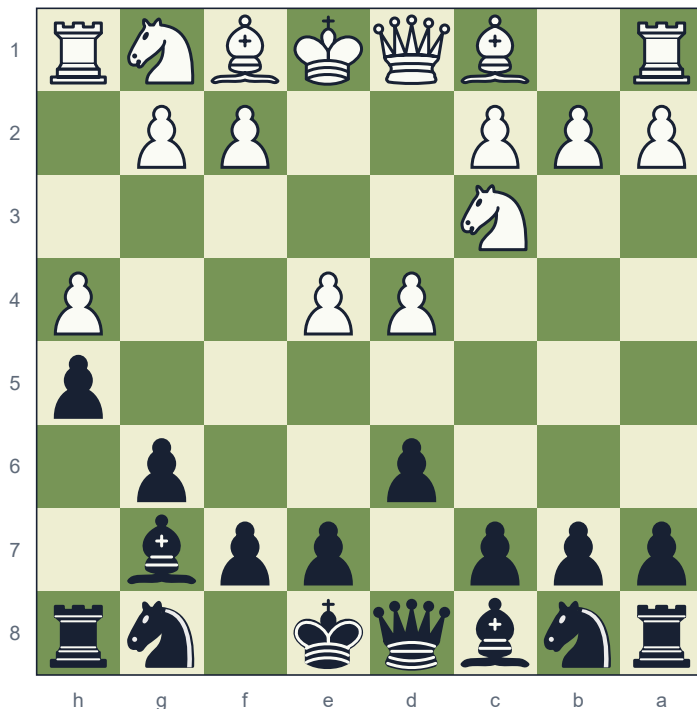
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Opening the center may activate White's fianchetto bishop too. The long diagonal to b7 can become a weakness.

BOARD DRILL

Mark the first blocker for each bishop and calculate one legal way to change it.

Against h4 and g4



HB-10 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

A wing attack is a concrete timing problem. ...h5 can stop one lever, while central action may punish the time White spent on pawns. Both choices can also create weaknesses.

HOW TO DECIDE

Calculate pawn captures and rook files before deciding. Keep the king flexible if castling would walk into an open file. Do not automatically play ...h6 as a visual part of the formation.

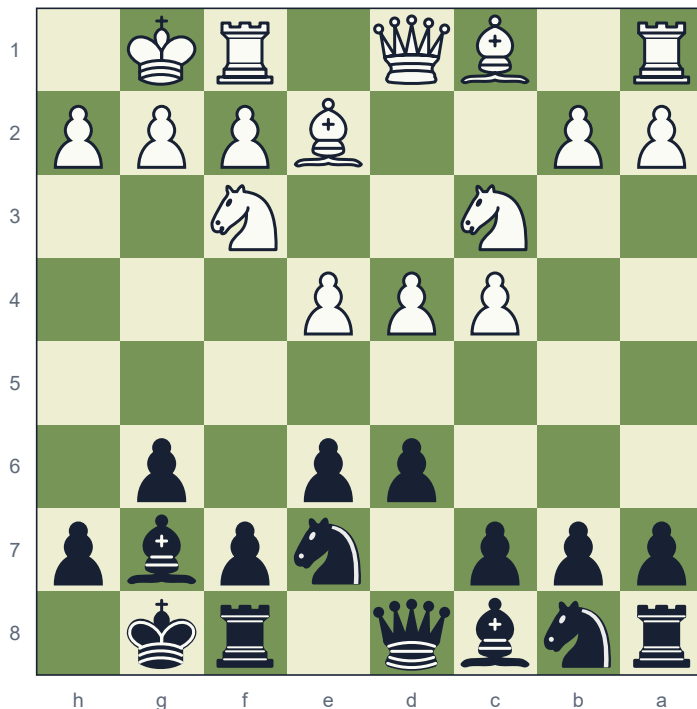
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White can use g4 to attack h5 or Bh6 to exchange Bg7. A blocked h-file may still be opened by another pawn contact.

BOARD DRILL

Compare the immediate h4 branch with the g4 branch and state why the defensive move order differs.

Large centers require earlier action



HB-07 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

Against c4-d4-e4 or an added f4, a full Hippo often gives White too much time and space. A partial formation with prompt development is the practical priority.

HOW TO DECIDE

Finish the king side and prepare a supported ...c5 or ...d5. Calculate e5 before every quiet move. Judge the resulting position honestly even when White retains an edge.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White can consolidate and then attack on either wing. Do not rely on the opponent overextending without actively testing the center.

BOARD DRILL

Play the four-pawn endpoint from both sides. Black's task is to create a safe break; White's is to prevent it.

King safety is a decision



HB-03 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

A closed center can make delayed castling workable, but a central break can expose the king suddenly. A queen on h6 or an open h-file can make short castling especially dangerous.

HOW TO DECIDE

Inspect open lines, central pawn contacts and the opponent's castling choice. Compare castling with a central exchange or a developing defensive move.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White may keep the king flexible while preparing Bh6 and h4. A king destination chosen on habit can become the attack's target.

BOARD DRILL

In three diagrams, decide whether castling is legal, then separately whether it looks strategically safe.

Do not fear a partial Hippo



HB-18 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

After 1.b3 g6 2.Bb2, the bishop already attacks g7. Developing Nf6 first blocks that diagonal. The correct position has a knight on f6 rather than e7.

HOW TO DECIDE

Check every long diagonal before placing an undefended bishop. Use normal development and central control when the opponent's move order prevents the preferred arrangement.

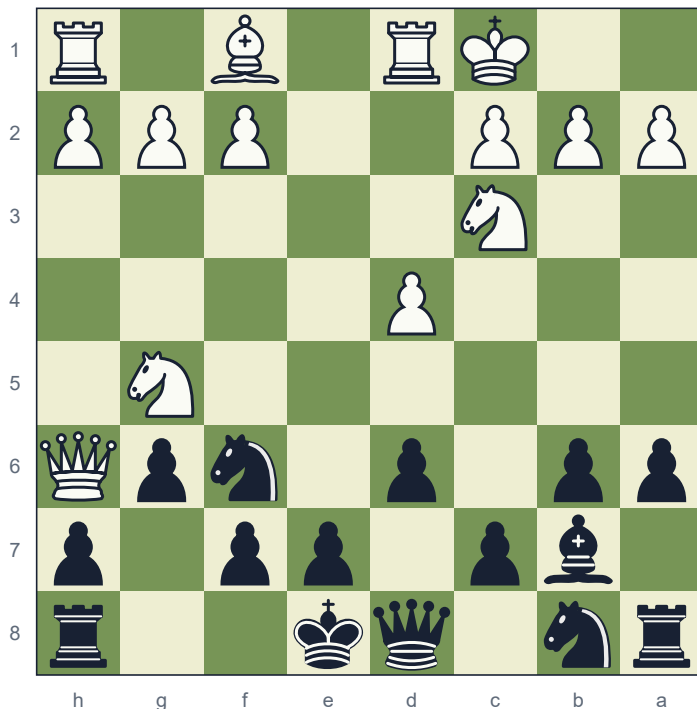
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Bishop captures and queen checks can punish an apparently standard fianchetto. An opening name cannot justify leaving a piece en prise.

BOARD DRILL

Reconstruct this branch and prove why immediate ...Bg7 loses a bishop. Then explain how ...Nf6 changes the board.

Loose pieces and forks



HB-03 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

Before calculating an attack, list undefended pieces. A knight fork attacks two targets that cannot both move away. A queen check may combine king pressure with a second target. If you remove a defender, inspect every piece it protected.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Find two pieces that would be vulnerable if their defender moved. Calculate one legal forcing move that tests the relation. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

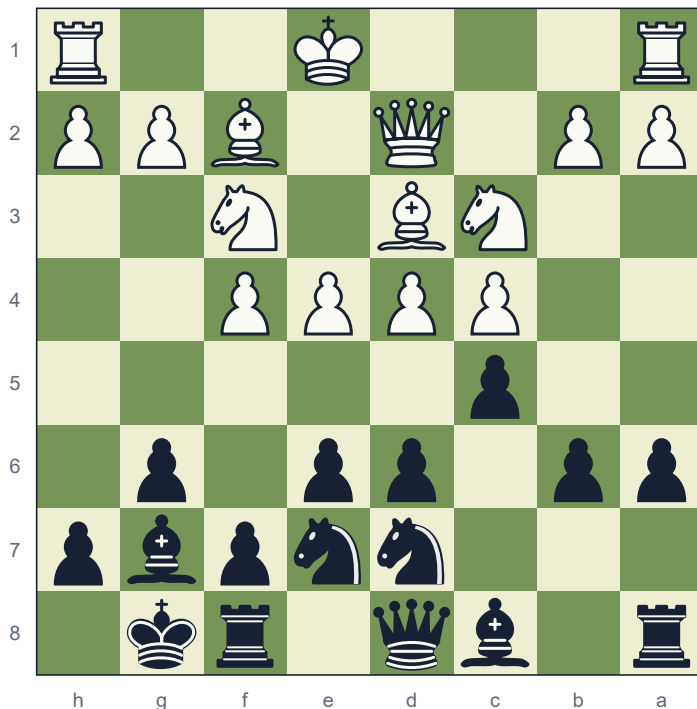
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

White can castle long and push h4. Removing the fianchetto bishop may weaken dark squares around a castled black king.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Pins and discovered attacks



HB-08 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

An absolute pin prevents a piece from moving if doing so exposes its king. A relative pin involves a valuable piece behind it, usually the queen. A discovered attack appears when a blocking piece moves away. Always trace the entire line, including the piece behind the blocker.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Identify a line piece, its blocker and the target behind it. If no pin exists, explain which required element is missing. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

White's attack may become dangerous if allowed to consolidate every pawn. You need a break, not merely a compact-looking position.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Intermediate moves and defensive resources



HB-13 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

A recapture is not compulsory unless it is the only legal response to check. Before recapturing, inspect checks, stronger captures and direct threats. When attacking, give the defender the same opportunity; do not assume automatic recaptures.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

At a capture in your line, pause before the reply. List all legal checks, then compare them with the expected recapture. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

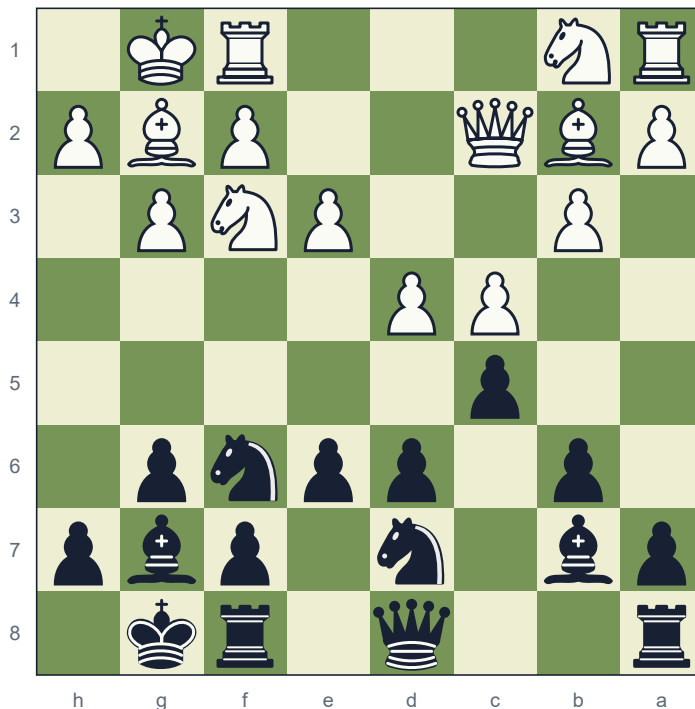
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

White can use Nbd2, c3 and e4 to expand. The London label does not guarantee that White will remain passive.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

A sacrifice needs a stopping point



HB-18 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

Calculate a sacrifice until the defender has a stable reply you can evaluate. Count material after the whole sequence, not after the first capture. If the line ends only with a vague promise of attack, compare a non-sacrificial candidate.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Choose a tempting sacrifice from a laboratory or your own game. Write the best defensive reply and the position where you stop calculating. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

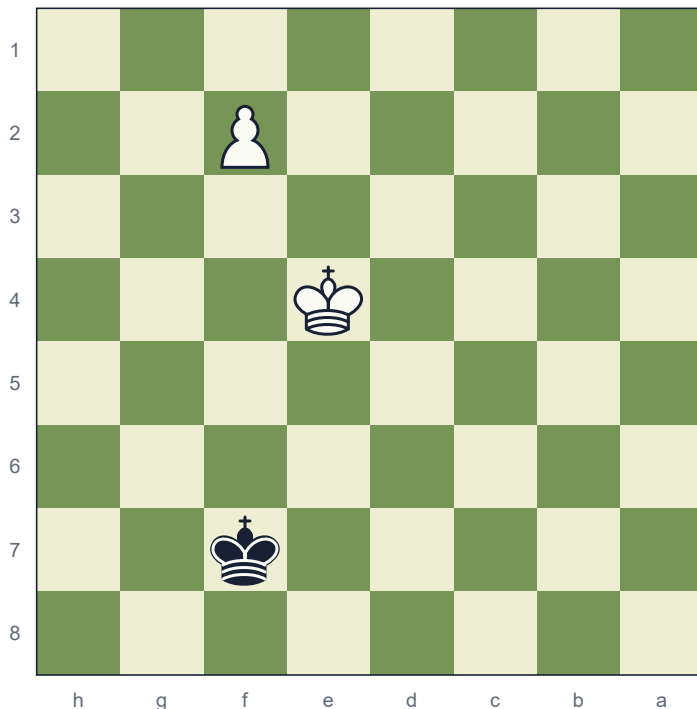
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

Playing ...Bg7 immediately after Bb2 would simply leave that bishop en prise. A normal-looking fianchetto is not safe in every move order.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Activate the king when queens are gone



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

White to move: Kf5 is a legal active king move. Kf4 is also legal but less direct; compare plans rather than inventing a forcing win. The general lesson is to bring the king toward the pawn and useful squares while keeping the opposing king out.

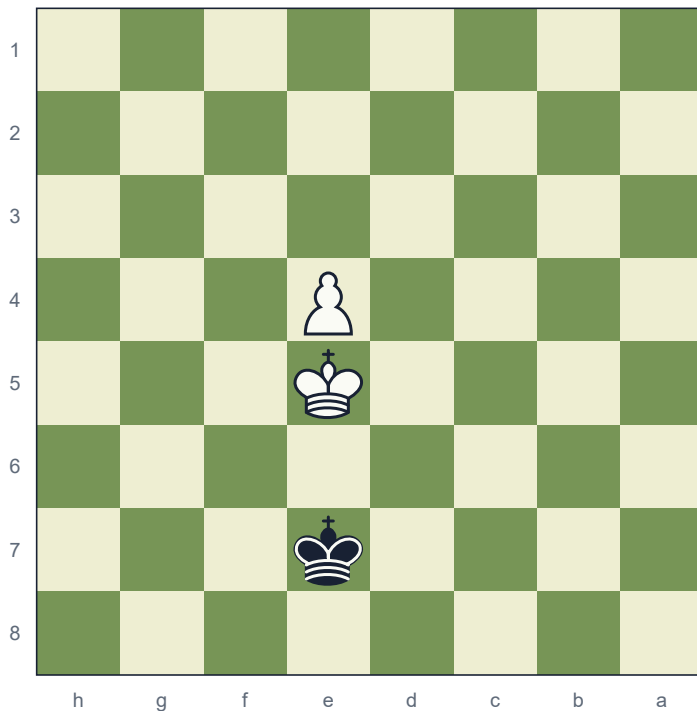
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

In an opening-to-endgame transition, first inspect checks and pawn threats, then activate the king. Do not continue making shelter moves whose main purpose was defense against a queen. A rook ending may still require care about checks from behind.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Opposition and the importance of the move



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

The kings face each other on e5 and e7 with one square between. White to move must give way or move the pawn; the geometry changes if Black is to move. Opposition is a tool for gaining entry squares, not a rule that always wins.

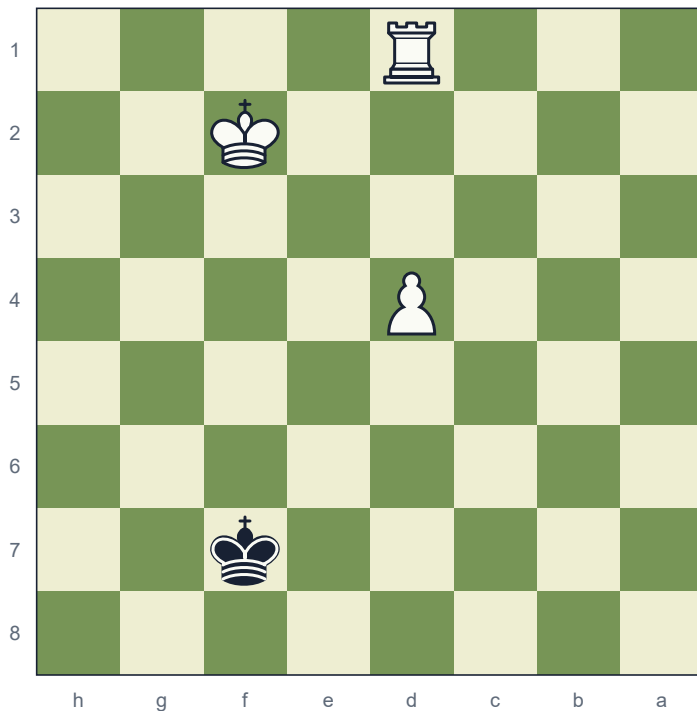
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

Replay both side-to-move versions. Track the pawn's key squares and whether the attacking king can reach them. If you exchange into a pawn ending, calculate the actual king route and tempo rather than relying on the extra pawn alone.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Rooks belong where they work



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

The rook on d1 stands behind its own passed d-pawn. As the pawn advances, the rook can continue supporting it from behind. This is a teaching position, not a claim of a difficult theoretical win against a rook.

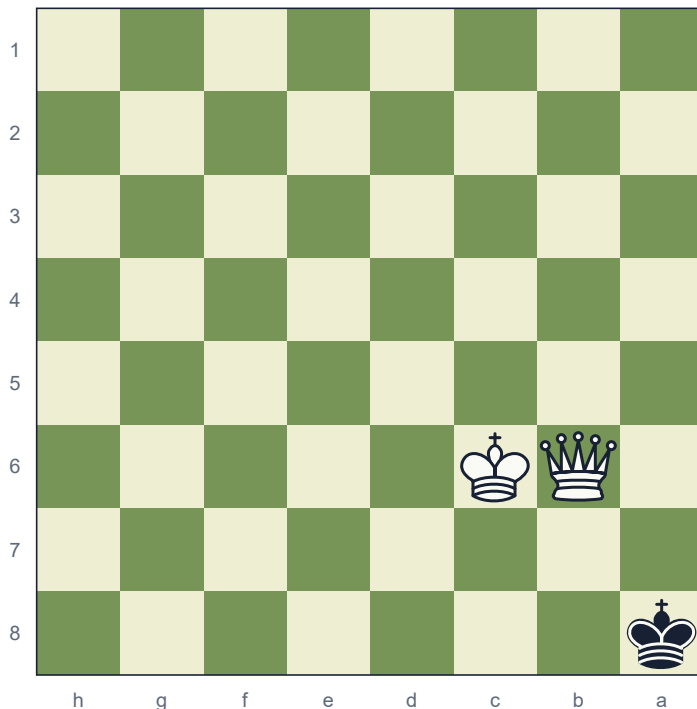
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

In real rook endings compare activity, checking distance, king shelter and pawn races. Putting a rook behind a passed pawn is a useful default, but a tactical threat or a decisive lateral check can override it. Do not trade an active rook into a lost pawn ending.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Recognize stalemate before promoting



Teaching position - Black to move

READ THE BOARD

Black to move is not in check and has no legal move: a7 and b8 are controlled by Qb6, while b7 is controlled by the queen and Kc6. This is stalemate, so the position is a draw despite White's extra queen.

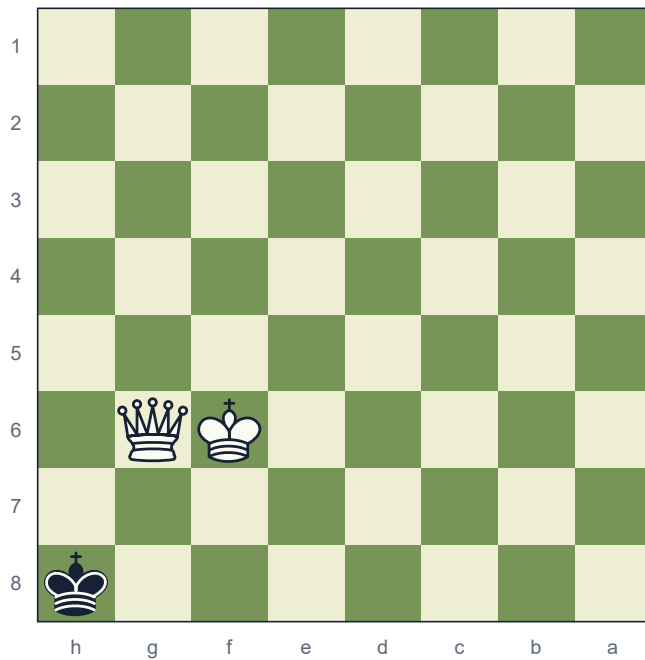
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

Before delivering the final move of a won game, check whether the opponent has a legal reply if not in check. In queen-versus-king technique, restrict the king with the queen, approach with your king and preserve a legal waiting square until you can give mate.

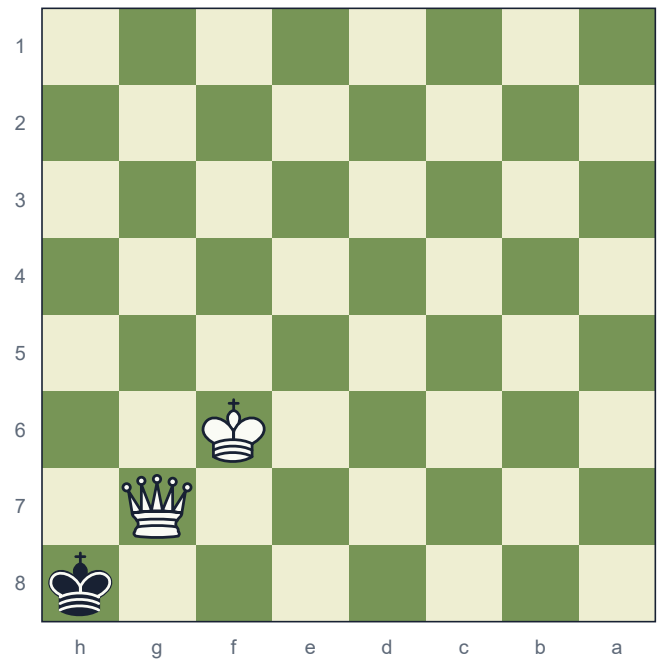
PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Finish a won queen ending



White to move - find mate in one



After Qg7# - Black is checkmated

WHY THIS IS MATE

Qg7 gives check along the g7-h8 diagonal. The white king on f6 protects the queen, so ...Kxg7 is illegal. The queen controls g8 and h7, removing the remaining escape squares. This proof checks attacks and legal replies, not just the appearance of the diagram.

TECHNIQUE BEFORE THE FINAL MOVE

Use the queen to reduce the enemy king's space, bring your king close enough to support the mate, and keep a legal waiting square until you can give checkmate. A queen alone can accidentally stalemate; review the previous lesson before repeating this drill.

Choosing the right exchanges

DO NOT TRADE BY HABIT

When offered a trade, compare the activity of the pieces leaving the board, the resulting pawn weaknesses and the king positions. A player with less space may welcome exchanges, but trading the only active piece can make the position worse.

PAWN ENDING TEST

Before exchanging the last pieces, calculate king activity, passed-pawn races and the side to move. Opposition is one tool; it is not a substitute for counting legal tempi. A pawn ending is often less forgiving than a rook ending.

OPENING-SPECIFIC QUESTION

After 1.b3 g6 2.Bb2, the bishop already attacks g7. Developing Nf6 first blocks that diagonal. The correct position has a knight on f6 rather than e7.

PRACTICAL CONVERSION

When ahead, neutralize counterplay and improve the least active piece before collecting another pawn. When defending, seek active checks, pawn breaks and useful exchanges rather than passive waiting.

A STUDY HABIT

After every practice game, keep one transition position. Record which exchange you chose, which alternative you considered and how the pawn structure changed.